

THE

1% Rule

*A Practical Guide to Transforming Your Life
with Small, Consistent Steps*

VEER SUKHADIYA



VEER SUKHADIYA BOOKS

The 1% Rule — Expanded Edition

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Stories marked "Real-world example" describe real people, organisations and studies, summarised from published sources listed in the Notes. Stories marked "Case study" are illustrative composites drawn from common experience.

Set in Source Serif, Inter and Space Grotesk.

INSIDE

Contents

PART ONE — THE PRINCIPLE

—	Introduction	7
01	The Power of 1%	11
02	The Math of Compounding	17

PART TWO — THE 1% IN EVERYDAY LIFE

03	1% in Health	25
04	1% in Learning	31
05	1% in Money	37
06	1% in Productivity	43
07	1% in Relationships	49

PART THREE — KEEP IT MOVING

08	The Momentum Effect	57
09	Stories of 1% Heroes	63
10	The 30-Day Blueprint	69

PART FOUR — GOING DEEPER

11	The Science of Small Wins	77
12	Breaking the 0% Mindset	83
13	Invisible Progress	89
14	The 1% Rule at Work	93
15	The 1% Rule for Health & Fitness	99
16	The 1% Life Plan	105
—	Conclusion	109

BACK MATTER

—	Acknowledgements	111
—	About the Author	111
—	Notes & Sources	113

PART ONE

01

The Principle

Why the smallest possible improvement is the most powerful one — and the simple mathematics that turns tiny actions into life-changing results.

Introduction

Why quiet, steady, invisible change beats the grand gesture — and what this book will help you build.

Small actions, repeated, always win.

THE 1% RULE

We live in a world that glorifies grand gestures: overnight success stories, dramatic makeovers, sudden breakthroughs. Scroll through any social feed and you will see them — the “before and after” photo, the startup that became a unicorn in a year, the person who quit everything and reinvented themselves in a single summer.

Yet most real change happens quietly, steadily, and invisibly. The before-and-after photo hides three hundred ordinary mornings. The “overnight” startup hides a decade of small experiments. The reinvention hides thousands of tiny, unglamorous decisions that nobody filmed.

The 1% Rule is a small, beautiful idea with massive consequence: **improve by one percent today, repeat tomorrow, and keep going.** Over weeks and months this tiny improvement compounds into a better life — a stronger body, a sharper mind, healthier finances. An unstoppable you.

THE IDEA

Why small beats big

Big goals are exciting on the first day and exhausting on the tenth. They depend on motivation, and motivation is a mood — it comes and goes with sleep, stress, weather and a hundred other things you don't control. When the mood leaves, the big goal leaves with it.

A 1% action is different. It is so small that you can do it on your worst day: tired, busy, travelling, uninspired. Because you can always do it, you actually do it. And because you actually do it, it adds up. The 1% Rule is not a trick for doing more in one day; it is a system for never having a zero day.

37.8×

How much better you'd be after a year of 1% daily gains (1.01^{365})

0.03×

What's left after a year of 1% daily decline (0.99^{365})

1

Micro-action is all you need to begin — today

Those numbers are not a promise that life is a neat spreadsheet. They are a picture of direction. Tiny choices, repeated, pull you somewhere — either up or down. The 1% Rule makes sure the pull is upward.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Kaizen: a whole philosophy of 1%

In post-war Japan, manufacturers such as Toyota built a culture around *kaizen* — a Japanese word usually translated as “continuous improvement”. Instead of waiting for a single brilliant redesign, every worker on the factory floor was encouraged to spot and fix small problems every day. Masaaki Imai’s 1986 book *Kaizen* brought the idea to the rest of the world, and it became one of the most studied management ideas of the twentieth century. The principle inside it is the same one in this book: small, continuous improvements, made by ordinary people, beat rare heroic leaps.

INSIDE

What you’ll find in this book

In these pages you’ll find the science behind small wins, the mindset to stay consistent, practical steps across health, learning, money, productivity and relationships, and a 30-day blueprint to get you started immediately. The book is organised in four parts:

- **Part One — The Principle.** What the 1% Rule is, why it works on the human brain, and the simple mathematics of compounding.
- **Part Two — The 1% in Everyday Life.** Micro-actions for your health, learning, money, productivity and relationships.
- **Part Three — Keep It Moving.** How momentum is built, stories of 1% heroes, and the complete 30-Day Blueprint.
- **Part Four — Going Deeper.** The science of small wins, breaking the 0% mindset, invisible progress, the 1% Rule at work, health and fitness, and your 1% Life Plan.

Every chapter ends with **Action Steps** you can do the same day and a **Key Takeaway** you can carry in your head. You’ll also find **Real-world**

THE 1% RULE

examples — true stories of people, teams and studies that show the 1% Rule working outside the pages of a book.

HOW TO READ IT

Don't just read — try

You could read this book in a weekend. Please don't stop there. The best way to use it is to pick one micro-action from the first chapter that speaks to you and start it *before* you finish the book. By the time you reach the 30-Day Blueprint in Chapter 10 you will already have a few days of proof that this works for you.

“Small actions, repeated, always win.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Write down one area of your life you'd like to be 1% better in by tomorrow.
- ☐ Choose the smallest useful action you could take in that area today — something that takes less than five minutes.
- ☐ Do it before you start Chapter 1. Then put a tick on your calendar.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Start with the smallest useful action. Consistency matters more than intensity.

The Power of 1%

Life rewards the person who shows up. This chapter explains why the smallest possible step is the smartest place to start.

Progress, not perfection — one tiny step at a time.

THE 1% RULE

We admire the dramatic transformations in movies — the training montage, the big speech, the sudden turn-around. But day-to-day life rewards something much less cinematic: the person who shows up.

The 1% Rule is not about grand gestures; it's about micro-actions. It is the art of making the smallest possible improvement you can imagine — then repeating it habitually. One push-up. Five minutes of learning. One extra glass of water. None of these will change your life today. All of them, repeated, will change your life this year.

THE QUESTION

Why 1%?

Because tiny changes remove friction. Friction is everything that stands between you and starting: the effort to change clothes for the gym, the mental weight of a 300-page textbook, the discomfort of a difficult conversation. The bigger the task, the more friction it carries — and the more likely you are to postpone it.

THE 1% RULE

Shrink the task, and the friction almost disappears. You are far more likely to start the smallest of actions: one push-up, five minutes of learning, one extra glass of water. And starting is the whole game. Once you start, you often do more than you planned. Even when you don't, you've kept the promise — and each small success lights up the reward centres in the brain and creates momentum.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The aggregation of marginal gains

When Sir Dave Brailsford became performance director of British Cycling in 2003, British riders had won very little on the world stage. His strategy was deceptively simple: break everything that affects performance into tiny parts, and improve each one by about one percent.

The team tested bike fit and aerodynamics, but also things no one else bothered with — which pillow helped riders sleep best (and taking it to every hotel), how to wash hands to avoid catching colds, heated shorts to keep muscles warm between races, even painting the inside of the team truck white so tiny particles of dust that could affect the bikes were easy to spot.

None of these changes was dramatic. Together they were. British cycling dominated the track at the Beijing 2008 and London 2012 Olympics, and in 2012 Bradley Wiggins became the first British rider to win the Tour de France with Brailsford's Team Sky.

Brailsford's later years with Team Sky drew scrutiny on other matters, but the "marginal gains" method itself has since been adopted across sport and business.

THE PSYCHOLOGY

The three pillars of the 1% Rule

The psychology behind the 1% Rule rests on three pillars. Understand them and you'll know why it works — and how to fix it when it doesn't.

1. Identity Reinforcement

Small actions gradually rewrite who you believe you are. Every time you do your micro-action, you cast a small vote for a new identity. One walk doesn't make you "a fit person". Thirty walks start to. A hundred walks and it would feel strange *not* to walk. You stop saying "I'm trying to exercise" and start saying "I'm someone who moves every day." That shift in self-description is what makes the habit last long after motivation fades.

2. Reward Consistency

Tiny wins deliver reliable reward signals, encouraging repetition. A giant goal gives you one reward at the very end — if you ever get there. A 1% goal gives you a small reward every single day: the tick on the calendar, the feeling of "I did it". The brain learns quickly from frequent, predictable rewards, and it learns to come back for more.

3. Reduced Resistance

The smaller the task, the lower the resistance to begin. It is hard to argue yourself out of something that takes two minutes. There is no "I don't have time", no "I'm too tired", no "I'll do it properly tomorrow". The task is too small to fight.

IDENTITY

"I am someone who..."

Small actions are votes for the person you want to become.

REWARD

A win every day

Frequent small rewards train the brain to repeat the action.

RESISTANCE

Too small to fight

Shrink the task until starting feels effortless.

RESULT

Momentum

Identity + reward + low resistance = a habit that sticks.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Two push-ups and one tooth

Stanford behaviour scientist BJ Fogg spent years studying why people fail to change. His conclusion was that most people make new habits too big. To test the opposite approach on himself, he committed to two push-ups every time he used the bathroom. Two — nothing more. Over time the tiny habit grew on its own, to dozens of push-ups a day. His most famous suggestion for anyone who wants to start flossing is simply to floss *one tooth*. Fogg has since coached tens of thousands of people through this “tiny habits” method, which he describes in his 2019 book *Tiny Habits*.

IN PRACTICE

Practical steps to begin

You don’t need a new app, a new notebook or a new year to start. You need three decisions:

- **Pick an area:** health, learning, money, relationships, or productivity. Just one to begin with.
- **Choose a micro-action you can do even on your worst day.** If you’re not sure it’s small enough, make it smaller. Five minutes is plenty; two minutes is fine.
- **Track it visibly.** The simple act of checking a box keeps consistency alive. A paper calendar on the wall works better than you’d expect because you see it every day.

AREA	TOO BIG (EASY TO SKIP)	1% VERSION (HARD TO SKIP)
Health	"Go to the gym for an hour"	One push-up after brushing your teeth
Learning	"Finish a course this month"	Five minutes of a lesson with morning tea
Money	"Start saving seriously"	Move ₹20 to savings every evening
Relationships	"Be a better friend"	Send one sincere message each morning
Productivity	"Get organised"	Clear one shelf, or one inbox folder

CASE STUDY

Ananya's one-page habit

Ananya, a college student, had been "meaning to read more" for three years. Every January she set a goal of 30 books. Every February she quietly abandoned it. This time she chose a 1% version: read one page before bed. Some nights she read one page and slept. Most nights one page turned into ten. After six months she had finished nine books — more than the previous three years combined. The goal didn't get bigger. The habit did.

“Progress, not perfection — one tiny step at a time.

THE 1% RULE

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose one micro-action you can do on any day — even your busiest, most tired day.
- ☐ Tie it to something you already do (after brushing your teeth, after your morning tea).
- ☐ Track it for 30 days on a visible calendar. Don't judge the size; just protect the streak.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Small, repeatable actions build identity and momentum.

The Math of Compounding

One percent looks like nothing on paper. Repeated for a year, it becomes almost thirty-eight times better.

Numbers sometimes hide a quiet magic.

CHAPTER 2

Numbers sometimes hide a quiet magic. The expression 1.01^{365} looks small on paper — a one, a decimal point, a tiny exponent. In practice it becomes enormous.

One percent better per day becomes roughly **37 times better** after a year. That's the mathematics of compound improvement: each day's gain is built on top of all the gains before it, so the growth doesn't just add up — it multiplies.

$$1.01^{365} = 37.78 \quad \cdot \quad 0.99^{365} = 0.03$$

One percent better every day for a year, versus one percent worse every day for a year.

THE 1% RULE

TWO DIRECTIONS

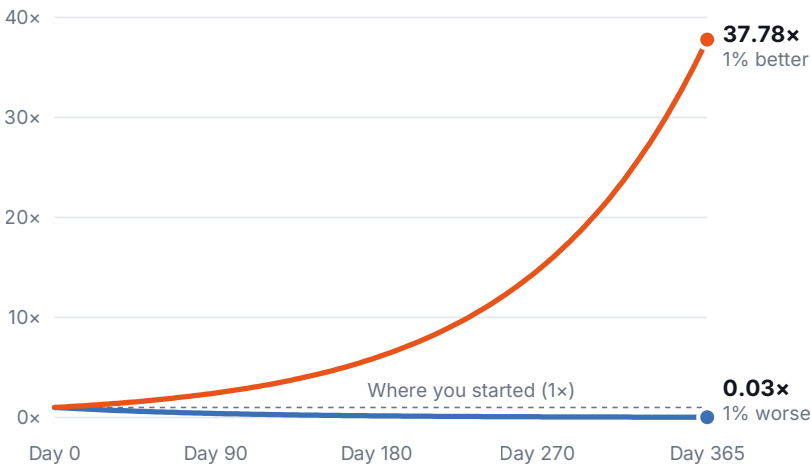
Compounding works both ways

Conversely, small declines compound against you. A 1% worse each day — 0.99^{365} — shrinks your results to almost nothing. After a year you would be left with about three percent of where you started.

This dual nature of compounding means the difference between small positive choices and small negative choices grows over time into a canyon of results. On any single day, the two paths look identical. Skipping one workout doesn't make you unfit. Eating one salad doesn't make you healthy. Spending an hour scrolling doesn't ruin your career. The gap is invisible on day one and enormous by day three hundred and sixty-five.

The canyon between 1% better and 1% worse

Result relative to your starting point, day by day over one year



Read it this way: for the first two months both lines hug the starting point. The difference only becomes dramatic in the second half of the year — which is exactly why most people give up too early.

CHECKPOINT	1% BETTER DAILY	1% WORSE DAILY
After 1 week	1.07×	0.93×
After 30 days	1.35×	0.74×
After 90 days	2.45×	0.40×
After 180 days	6.00×	0.16×
After 365 days	37.78×	0.03×

Of course, real life is not a laboratory. You won't literally become 37.78 times "better" at anything, and not every day will be a 1% gain. The point of the numbers is not precision; it is direction. Small, consistent choices always travel somewhere. The only question is which way.

WHERE IT SHOWS UP

Compounding in real life

Saving and investing

Small monthly contributions become comfortable wealth over decades. Money invested earns returns, and those returns begin to earn returns of their own. Early on, almost all of your balance is the money you put in. Later, most of it is growth. Chapter 5 shows exactly how this plays out with real rupee figures.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The investor whose fortune arrived late

Warren Buffett is often described as a brilliant stock-picker, and he is. But writer Morgan Housel points out something more surprising in *The Psychology of Money* (2020): of Buffett's roughly \$84.5 billion net worth at the time of writing, around \$81.5 billion came *after* his 65th birthday. Buffett started investing as a boy and simply never stopped. His real secret, Housel argues, is time — decades of steady compounding that nobody else was patient enough to wait for.

Skill practice

Fifteen minutes daily of deliberate practice adds up to years of focused improvement. Fifteen minutes a day is more than **91 hours a year** — the equivalent of more than two full working weeks devoted only to that skill. Ten years of that is over 900 focused hours, which is more practice than most people ever give to anything outside their job.

Health

Tiny adjustments in sleep and nutrition compound into energy, resilience and longevity. Going to bed thirty minutes earlier adds up to about 182 extra hours of sleep over a year — more than a week of rest. Replacing one sugary drink a day with water removes hundreds of empty calories each week without a single “diet”.

91 hrs

15 minutes of daily practice, over one year

182 hrs

Sleeping 30 minutes earlier, over one year

3,650

Pages read at just 10 pages a day for a year

MAKE IT WORK FOR YOU

Micro-goals that compound

This chapter also explains how to set micro-goals that compound, how to measure small improvements, and how to make 1% changes visible. Here is how.

1. Set micro-goals that can grow

A good micro-goal has a built-in path upward. “Walk five minutes after dinner” can become ten minutes, then fifteen. “Save ₹20 a day” can become ₹25, then ₹30. Start at a level you could keep even in a bad week, and only increase it when the current level feels almost boring.

2. Measure the small stuff

You can’t feel a 1% change, so you need to measure it. Pick one simple number: minutes practised, pages read, rupees saved, steps walked, days completed. Write it down every day. You are not measuring to judge yourself; you are measuring so you can see a trend that your feelings would otherwise miss.

3. Make 1% changes visible

Invisible progress is easy to abandon. Make it visible: a wall calendar full of ticks, a jar that fills with marbles, a simple chart on your phone. When you can see thirty ticks in a row, you won’t want to break the chain — and on the days you feel you’re getting nowhere, the chart will show you otherwise.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The Rule of 72

Investors use a simple shortcut to feel compounding: divide 72 by the yearly growth rate to estimate how many years it takes something to double. At 8% a year, money doubles roughly every 9 years ($72 \div 8$). At 12%, about every 6 years. The same idea applies to skills and habits — a steady rate of improvement, however small, has a “doubling time”. Keep going long enough and you pass it again and again.

“The difference between small positive choices and small negative choices grows into a canyon of results.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose one micro-action you can do on any day, and write down its “growth path” (for example: 5 → 10 → 15 minutes).
- ☐ Pick one number to measure it by, and record that number every day.
- ☐ Track it for 30 days on a visible calendar. At the end, compare day 1 with day 30.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Small, repeatable actions build identity and momentum — and compounding turns them into results.

PART TWO

02

The 1% in Everyday Life

Five areas of life, five sets of micro-actions. Health, learning, money, productivity and relationships — each one improved a single percent at a time.

03 Health · 04 Learning · 05 Money · 06 Productivity · 07 Relationships

1% in Health

Energy drives creativity, patience and focus. Small, sustainable health upgrades pay off in every other part of life.

Health is the foundation for everything else.

CHAPTER 3

Health is the foundation for everything else. Energy levels dictate creativity, patience and focus. When you sleep badly, you snap at people you love. When you're sluggish, the simplest task feels heavy. When you feel strong, everything else gets a little easier.

That is why a small, sustainable improvement in health creates out-sized benefits in every other area. You don't need a dramatic transformation. You need a body that has a bit more energy tomorrow than it had today.

WHY DIETS FAIL

The trap of the big health reset

Most health changes begin with enthusiasm and end in guilt. A new diet that removes every food you enjoy. A workout plan built for an athlete. A 5 a.m. wake-up alarm when you usually sleep at midnight. Each is a huge jump from your current life — and the bigger the jump, the harder the fall when a busy week arrives.

THE 1% RULE

The 1% approach flips this. Instead of asking “What is the ideal plan?”, ask “What is the smallest healthy change I could keep for the rest of my life?” The answer is usually almost embarrassingly small. That’s the point.

START HERE

Micro-steps to health

HYDRATION

One extra glass of water

Drink one extra glass of water daily for a month. Keep a full bottle where you can see it.

MOVEMENT

A 10-minute walk after meals

Add a short walk after lunch or dinner — even around your building.

NUTRITION

One whole-food swap

Replace one processed snack with a whole food: fruit, nuts, roasted chana, curd.

MOBILITY

Five minutes of stretching

Stretch for five minutes every morning before checking your phone.

Notice that none of these require a gym, special equipment or a new wardrobe. Each takes less than ten minutes. Each can be attached to something you already do: drinking water when you sit at your desk, walking after the meal you already eat, stretching before the phone you already pick up.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The power of a short walk after eating

A 2022 review of studies published in the journal *Sports Medicine* looked at what happens when people interrupt sitting after a meal with light activity. Researchers found that even a brief, easy walk of just two to five minutes after eating helped lower blood-sugar levels compared with staying seated. Longer walks help more — but the headline is how little it takes to make a measurable difference. The 10-minute walk after meals in this chapter is a 1% change with real physiology behind it.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Japan's three-minute morning ritual

Since 1928, Japan has broadcast *Rajio Taisō* — “radio exercises” — a short routine of simple stretches and movements set to piano music that takes about three minutes. For generations, schoolchildren, factory workers, office teams and retirees in parks have done it together each morning. It is not a workout that builds big muscles. It is a tiny daily movement habit, repeated for almost a century, that has become part of a nation's routine.

Raj's journey

CASE STUDY

From five minutes to a new life

Raj was an office worker who felt tired, overweight and uninspired. He had tried gym memberships twice and quit both within a month. His evenings were spent on the sofa with his phone, and his mornings started with coffee and dread.

He began with a single change: a five-minute walk every day after dinner. Not a run, not a workout — just a walk to the end of the street and back.

Within two weeks he slept better. The walk helped him digest, cleared his head, and pulled him away from the screen.

Within two months he was adding another five minutes, then another. His walks became twenty minutes, and he started taking the stairs at work without thinking about it.

Over a year, small improvements led Raj to lose weight, gain energy, and finally adopt regular exercise. The details show that the change was hardly dramatic — it was consistent.

Look closely at Raj's story and you'll see all three pillars from Chapter 1. His *identity* shifted from "someone who can't stick to exercise" to "someone who walks every evening". He got a *reward* quickly — better sleep within two weeks. And the *resistance* was so low that there was never a good reason to skip.

MAKING IT LAST

Rules for health habits that stick

- **Start below your ability.** If you could walk thirty minutes, start with ten. You are training consistency first, fitness second.

- **Link it to an anchor.** “After dinner, I walk.” “After I brush my teeth, I stretch.” The existing habit reminds you of the new one.
- **Prepare the environment.** Put your walking shoes by the door. Keep the water bottle full on your desk. Put fruit where the biscuits used to be.
- **Never miss twice.** Missing one day is life. Missing two days is the start of a new habit — the wrong one.
- **Grow it slowly.** Add five minutes or one glass only when the current level feels easy.

Always check with a doctor before starting a new exercise routine if you have a medical condition, are pregnant, or have been inactive for a long time.

“The change was hardly dramatic — it was consistent.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose one health micro-action from this chapter that you can do on any day.
- ☐ Attach it to an existing routine — a meal, your morning tea, or brushing your teeth.
- ☐ Track it for 30 days on a visible calendar, and note your energy level (1–10) each evening.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Small, repeatable actions build identity and momentum. In health, energy is the first dividend.

1% in Learning

Knowledge compounds faster than almost anything. Ten pages, one word, one problem — every day.

Knowledge compounds faster than most things.

CHAPTER 4

Knowledge compounds faster than most things. Every idea you learn connects to the ideas you already know, making the next idea easier to understand and remember. Reading ten pages a day, writing a short note, or solving one extra problem daily creates a person who is always improving.

The 1% learner doesn't wait for a long holiday to "finally learn" something. They learn in small pieces, every day, in the gaps of ordinary life — on the bus, before bed, with morning tea. Over a year those small pieces become a genuine education.

3,650

Pages a year from reading
10 pages a day

12–15

Average-length books that
adds up to

365

New words if you learn just
one a day

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

“Knowledge builds up, like compound interest”

Warren Buffett has said for decades that reading is the core of his working day. Speaking to a group of students, he reportedly held up a stack of papers and reports and told them to read 500 pages like that every day — “That’s how knowledge works. It builds up, like compound interest.” He added that everyone could do it, but most people won’t. His long-time partner Charlie Munger described Buffett as “a learning machine”. You don’t need 500 pages. Ten is enough to start the same compounding process.

START HERE

Practical learning micro-actions**READ****10 pages before bed**

Keep the book on your pillow so you see it before your phone.

VOCABULARY**One new word — and use it**

Learn one word each day and use it in a sentence, a message or a note.

PRACTICE**One problem a day**

Practise one problem in mathematics or a language every day.

TEACH**Explain it to someone**

Teaching is one of the fastest ways to master anything you learn.

Why teaching works so well

When you teach, you can’t hide behind vague understanding. You have to organise the idea, find simple words, and answer “why?” Psychologists call the benefit the *protégé effect*: people who learn something expecting to teach it tend to organise and remember it better than people who learn it only for a test. The physicist Richard Feynman was famous for this approach — if he couldn’t explain an idea simply, he took it as a sign he didn’t understand it well enough yet. Today, the “Feynman technique” is used by students everywhere:

learn it, explain it in plain words, notice the gaps, and go back to fill them.

HOW TO

Design micro-learning sessions

Use the Pomodoro technique in mini-sessions

The Pomodoro technique was created by Francesco Cirillo in the late 1980s, when he was a university student struggling to focus. He grabbed a tomato-shaped kitchen timer (*pomodoro* is Italian for tomato) and challenged himself to study for just a few focused minutes. For the 1% learner, a simple version works beautifully: **15 minutes, twice a day**. Set a timer, remove your phone from the room, and learn only one thing until it rings.

Keep a learning notebook

Keep a ‘learning notebook’ with summaries, questions and reflections. It can be paper or a notes app. Each entry takes two minutes: what you studied, one key idea in your own words, and one question you still have. Over months, this notebook becomes a personal textbook written by the only author who knows exactly how you think.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Leonardo’s notebooks

Leonardo da Vinci filled notebooks throughout his life with sketches, observations, questions and to-do lists — how birds fly, how water swirls, how the tongue of a woodpecker works. Thousands of these pages survive today. Many entries are tiny: one drawing, one question, one idea. Together they form one of the greatest records of human curiosity ever made. Leonardo’s genius was real, but so was his daily habit of writing down what he noticed.

Turn passive reading into active learning

Reading without thinking is like pouring water into a glass with no bottom. After every chapter you read, ask yourself three questions:

QUESTION	WHY IT WORKS
What did I learn?	Forces you to recall and summarise — the act of retrieval strengthens memory.
What surprised me?	Surprise marks the point where your old understanding changed.
How can I apply this?	Turns information into action — the only kind of knowledge that changes your life.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The forgetting curve

In the 1880s, German psychologist Hermann Ebbinghaus tested his own memory by learning lists of nonsense syllables and checking how many he could recall over time. He found that memories fade quickly at first — much of what we learn is lost within days — unless it is reviewed. Each review slows the forgetting. This is why short, regular learning sessions beat one long cramming session: little and often keeps knowledge alive. Modern flashcard apps built on “spaced repetition” are based on the same discovery.

“Ten pages a day doesn’t feel like much. Ten pages a day for a year is a library.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose one learning micro-action you can do on any day — 10 pages, one word, or one problem.
- ☐ Start a learning notebook tonight. Write one sentence about what you learned today.
- ☐ Track it for 30 days on a visible calendar. At the end, teach one idea to a friend.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Small, repeatable actions build identity and momentum. Knowledge is the fastest compounder of all.

1% in Money

Financial fitness is built from tiny habitual choices, not windfalls. Automate the small things and let time do the heavy lifting.

Financial fitness is less about windfalls and more about tiny habitual choices.

CHAPTER 5

Financial fitness is less about windfalls and more about tiny habitual choices. Saving a small portion of income, investing regular micro-amounts, avoiding impulsive purchases — these are the 1% moves that compound into security.

We tend to believe that wealth comes from big moments: a lottery win, a lucky stock tip, a sudden promotion. For most people, financial security is built the other way — quietly, in amounts that feel too small to matter, repeated for long enough that they add up to something large.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The janitor who left \$8 million

Ronald Read of Brattleboro, Vermont, worked for decades as a petrol-station attendant and later as a janitor. He drove an old car, wore simple clothes, and lived modestly. When he died in 2014 at the age of 92, his neighbours were stunned to learn he had built a fortune of roughly \$8 million. He had done it by saving steadily from an ordinary income and investing in well-known, dividend-paying companies — then holding them for decades. In his will he left around \$6 million to the local hospital and library. No windfall. No secret. Just small amounts, invested consistently, for a very long time.

START HERE

Daily money habits**ROUND UP****Save the difference**

Round up purchases and save the change. Spend ₹180? Move ₹20 to savings.

AUTOMATE**Invest on autopilot**

Automate a small portion of income into an investment account on payday.

AUDIT**One expense at a time**

Track one recurring expense and ask honestly: does this add value to my life?

PAUSE**The 48-hour rule**

Delay any non-essential purchase by 48 hours. Often the urge simply fades.

Round up and save the difference

Every time you spend, round the amount up to the next ₹50 or ₹100 and move the difference to a savings account. Many banking and payment apps can now do this for you automatically. The amounts feel invisible — ₹7 here, ₹32 there — but at an average of ₹20 a day, that is more than ₹7,000 a year saved without a single hard decision.

Automate a small portion of income

Decision fatigue is the enemy of saving. If you have to decide to save every month, some months you won't. So remove the decision. Set up an automatic transfer or a monthly Systematic Investment Plan (SIP) on the day your salary arrives. Start with an amount so small it doesn't hurt — 1% of your income is a perfect beginning. Then increase it by 1% every few months.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

“Save More Tomorrow”

Economists Richard Thaler (later a Nobel laureate) and Shlomo Benartzi designed a simple programme for employees who said they couldn't afford to save more. Instead of asking them to save more *now*, it asked them to commit a small part of each *future* pay rise to savings. In the first company to use it, participants' average saving rate rose from about 3.5% to 13.6% of income in roughly three and a half years. Nobody made a heroic sacrifice. They simply agreed to small, automatic increases — the 1% Rule applied to a pay slip.

Track one recurring expense

Don't try to budget your entire life on day one. Pick one recurring expense — a streaming subscription, daily takeaway coffee, food-delivery orders — and track it for a month. Then ask: does this add real value? If yes, keep it without guilt. If not, cancel or cut it, and send the saving straight to your investment account.

The 48-hour rule

Impulse purchases are driven by emotion in the moment. Put a gap between the wanting and the buying. Add the item to a wishlist and wait 48 hours. If you still want it — and can afford it — buy it happily. More often than you'd expect, the urge fades, and the money stays where it belongs.

THE 1% RULE

THE LONG GAME

Investing the 1%

Even a small amount invested with compounding returns becomes significant. The goal here is to prioritise consistency and remove decision fatigue with automation. Look at what happens to a modest ₹3,000 a month — about ₹100 a day:

₹3,000 a month, invested consistently

Total invested vs. estimated value, assuming a 12% average annual return, compounded monthly



Illustration only. Returns are assumed, not guaranteed; real markets rise and fall, and inflation reduces what money can buy. The shape of the curve is the lesson: in the early years your contributions do most of the work; in the later years, growth takes over.

YEARS INVEST-ING	TOTAL INVES-TED	ESTIMATED VALUE (12%)	GROWTH EARNED
10 years	₹3.6 lakh	≈ ₹7.0 lakh	≈ ₹3.4 lakh
20 years	₹7.2 lakh	≈ ₹30.0 lakh	≈ ₹22.8 lakh
30 years	₹10.8 lakh	≈ ₹1.06 crore	≈ ₹95 lakh

Notice the pattern. In the first ten years, growth roughly doubles what you put in. Between years twenty and thirty, the balance more

than triples — even though you add the same ₹3,000 every month. That is compounding: patience turns small, boring contributions into something life-changing. The single most powerful financial decision is not *how much* you start with, but *how early* you start and *how long* you keep going.

This chapter is general education, not financial advice. Consider your own goals and risk tolerance, and speak with a qualified, registered financial adviser before investing.

“Wealth is rarely a windfall. It is a habit with a long memory.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose one money micro-action you can do on any day — a round-up, a ₹20 transfer, or the 48-hour pause.
- ☐ Set up one automatic transfer this week, however small. Let payday do the saving for you.
- ☐ Track it for 30 days on a visible calendar, and write the total saved at the bottom.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Small, repeatable actions build identity and momentum. Automate the small things and let time do the heavy lifting.

1% in Productivity

Procrastination is rarely laziness. It is overwhelm — and the cure is to make the next step small enough to start.

Instead of ‘write a book’, write 200 words.

CHAPTER 6

Procrastination is rarely about laziness; it’s about overwhelm. When a task feels too big, too vague or too uncomfortable, the brain looks for relief — and finds it in the phone, the fridge, or “just one more video”.

Researchers who study procrastination, such as psychologists Tim Pynchyl and Fuschia Sirois, describe it less as a time-management problem and more as an *emotion*-management problem. We don’t avoid tasks because we are lazy; we avoid the bad feeling the task gives us. The 1% Rule attacks that feeling directly: it lets you reduce tasks into micro-actions that feel approachable.

THE 1% RULE

OVERWHELMING TASK

1% MICRO-ACTION

Write a book	Write 200 words
Clean the house	Clear one shelf
Prepare for the exam	Revise one topic for 15 minutes
Fix my finances	Check one bank statement
Build a portfolio	Finish one small piece today

200

Words written a day

73,000

Words in a year — the length of a full novel

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The novelist with a watch on his desk

Anthony Trollope, one of the most popular novelists of Victorian England, never wrote full-time for most of his career. He worked for the Post Office — where he is credited with helping introduce the red pillar box to Britain. So he wrote early in the morning, before work, with his watch in front of him, aiming for about 250 words every quarter of an hour. If he finished a novel with time left in his session, he simply began the next one. Working this way he produced 47 novels, along with many other books. His secret was not inspiration; it was a small, measurable daily quota.

TOOLKIT

Micro-productivity techniques

The 5-minute rule

If a task takes less than five minutes, do it immediately. Reply to the message, file the document, wash the cup. Small tasks left undone pile up into a mental weight that drains energy from the important work. The productivity writer David Allen popularised a similar

“two-minute rule” in his book *Getting Things Done*; five minutes gives you a little more room without letting small tasks take over your day.

Time-block micro-sprints

Work in focused sprints: **25 minutes focused, 5 minutes break**. This is the classic Pomodoro rhythm. During the sprint, one task only — no email, no notifications. During the break, stand up, drink water, look out of a window. Four sprints make nearly two hours of deep work, which is more than many people manage in an entire distracted day.

Define your “minimum viable progress”

Each morning, define the minimum viable progress for the day: the one small thing that means the day counted. Not your whole to-do list — just the one thing that moves your most important goal forward. On a great day you’ll do far more. On a terrible day you’ll still do that one thing, and the day won’t be a zero.

Build systems, not willpower

The right system removes daily decision fatigue and replaces it with automatic progress. A system is anything that makes the right action the default: a fixed writing time every morning, a weekly review every Sunday, a phone that stays in another room while you work, a recurring calendar block for your most important project.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Stop when it's going well

Ernest Hemingway described a simple trick for keeping momentum in his writing: stop for the day while you still know what happens next. He wrote that he would stop when things were going well, so that the next morning he could begin easily. Stephen King, in his memoir *On Writing*, describes a similar daily discipline — a target of about 2,000 words a day. Both approaches share the 1% logic: a fixed, repeatable unit of work, and a finish line that makes it easy to start again tomorrow.

CREATIVE LAYOUTS

Track progress, not just tasks

Use a 'done' list

Use a dedicated 'done' list that tracks 1% increments instead of a huge to-do list. A to-do list shows you everything you haven't done yet; by the end of most days it makes you feel behind. A done list shows you everything you *have* done. It turns invisible effort into visible progress and gives your brain the small win it needs to keep going.

TO-DO LIST

Shows what's missing

Grows faster than you can finish it.
Ends most days feeling behind.

DONE LIST

Shows what's moving

Captures every 1% increment. Ends every day with proof of progress.

Celebrate micro-wins

Celebrate micro-wins publicly or with a small ritual to lock in motivation. It can be as simple as a fist pump, crossing a line through the task with a bold pen, telling a friend, or posting your streak in a group chat. Celebration sounds silly, but it is how the brain learns: the good feeling right after the action tells it, "Do that again."

“ **Don’t aim to finish the mountain today. Aim to move one stone.**

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Take the task you’ve been avoiding and shrink it into a 1% version you could start in the next five minutes.
- ☐ Tomorrow morning, write your “minimum viable progress” for the day on a sticky note.
- ☐ Keep a done list for 30 days and review it every Sunday.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Small, repeatable actions build identity and momentum. Shrink the task until starting is easy.

1% in Relationships

Relationships thrive on attention, not perfection. A two-minute check-in beats an occasional grand gesture.

Relationships thrive on attention, not perfection.

CHAPTER 7

Relationships thrive on attention, not perfection. A single compliment, a two-minute check-in with someone, or a tiny act of service builds bonds more than grand gestures performed occasionally.

We often think of relationships in terms of big moments — anniversaries, weddings, birthday surprises, the long overdue reunion. Those matter. But the real strength of a relationship is built in the thousands of small, forgettable moments in between: the reply to a message, the cup of tea made without asking, the question that shows you were really listening.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The longest study of happiness

In 1938, researchers at Harvard University began following a group of young men — Harvard students and boys from some of Boston’s poorest neighbourhoods — to learn what makes a good life. The Harvard Study of Adult Development has continued for more than 85 years and now includes the participants’ children. Its current director, psychiatrist Robert Waldinger, summarises the clearest finding simply: good relationships keep us happier and healthier. Not wealth, not fame — the quality of our connections with other people. And quality, the study suggests, is built through steady, everyday care.

THE SCIENCE

Small moments, big predictions

Psychologist John Gottman has spent decades studying couples, many of them in a research apartment nicknamed the “Love Lab”. He noticed that partners constantly make small “bids” for attention — “Look at that bird”, “I had a strange day”, a sigh, a smile. The other person can turn *towards* the bid (“What happened?”), turn *away* (ignore it), or turn *against* it (“Can’t you see I’m busy?”).

86%

Of bids turned towards by couples still together at the six-year follow-up

33%

Of bids turned towards by couples who had divorced

In one well-known study, couples who were still married six years later had turned towards each other’s bids about 86% of the time. Couples who had divorced had done so only about 33% of the time. The difference wasn’t dramatic romance. It was a pattern of tiny responses — the 1% Rule of love.

START HERE

Micro-relationship habits**DAILY****One sincere message**

Send one sincere message every morning to a close contact.

NOTICE**Name one good trait**

Notice one positive trait of your partner or friend — and tell them.

WEEKLY**Help without a return**

Offer help once a week without expectation of anything back.

LISTEN**One follow-up question**

Practice active listening: ask one follow-up question in every conversation.

Why the follow-up question matters

Most conversations are two people waiting for their turn to talk. A single follow-up question — “What made it so hard?”, “How did that feel?”, “What happened next?” — changes the whole exchange. It proves you were listening. It invites the other person to go deeper. And it costs you nothing but a moment of curiosity.

STORIES

Small rituals, strong bonds

Small rituals — like two minutes of undivided attention when a partner enters the room — have saved marriages. Put the phone face-down. Look up. Ask about their day and listen to the answer. Two minutes. Every day. It sounds too small to matter, and that is exactly why it works: it is small enough to do even when you are tired, stressed, or distracted, which is when it matters most.

CASE STUDY**Meera and the two-minute rule**

Meera and Arjun had been married for eight years. Nothing was “wrong” — they were just busy, tired, and increasingly living parallel lives on two phones. After a counsellor’s suggestion, they tried one rule: when either of them came home, the other stopped what they were doing for two minutes. No screens. Just “How was your day?” and a real answer. Within a month, they noticed they were laughing more. Within three months, the two minutes often became twenty. The ritual didn’t fix everything. It reopened the door.

Networking, the 1% way

Networking becomes effortless when you commit to one small, thoughtful touchpoint each week. Forward an article to a former colleague with a one-line note. Congratulate someone on a new role. Introduce two people who could help each other. One message a week is 52 meaningful touchpoints a year — more relationship-building than most people do in a decade of awkward networking events.

● **REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE****The strength of weak ties**

In 1973, sociologist Mark Granovetter published a famous paper called “The Strength of Weak Ties”. He found that people often heard about new jobs not through close friends, but through acquaintances — people they saw only occasionally. Close friends tend to know the same things you know; weak ties connect you to new worlds. A small, regular habit of staying in touch keeps those weak ties alive, and you never know which one will open the next door.

“Grand gestures make memories. Small gestures make relationships.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose one relationship micro-action you can do on any day — a message, a compliment, or a follow-up question.
- ☐ Pick one person this week who deserves a small, thoughtful touch-point, and send it today.
- ☐ Track it for 30 days on a visible calendar, and notice how people respond.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Small, repeatable actions build identity and momentum. Attention is the currency of every relationship.

PART THREE

03

Keep It Moving

How momentum is built, what 1% heroes have in common, and a day-by-day blueprint for your first thirty days.

08 The Momentum Effect · 09 Stories of 1% Heroes · 10 The 30-Day Blueprint

The Momentum Effect

Momentum is the invisible currency of long-term achievement. Push hard at first — and then let the flywheel spin.

Momentum is the invisible currency of long-term achievement.

CHAPTER 8

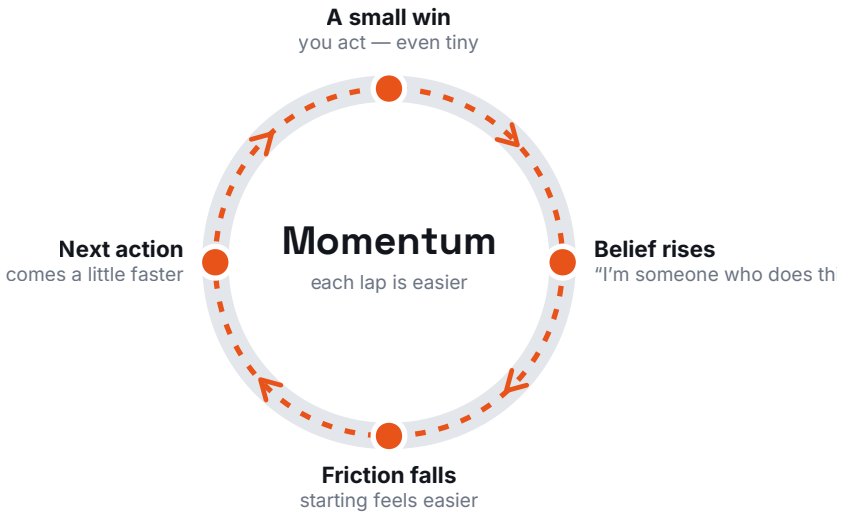
Momentum is the invisible currency of long-term achievement. Each small success increases your belief, reduces friction, and makes the next action easier.

Like a flywheel, at first you must push with effort; eventually the wheel spins with its own energy. The first push barely moves it. The tenth push moves it a little faster. By the hundredth push, the wheel is spinning with such force that it almost turns itself — and each push adds to the speed it already has.

THE 1% RULE

The momentum loop

Every small win makes the next one easier



● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The flywheel

In his book *Good to Great* (2001), researcher Jim Collins studied companies that made the leap from average results to outstanding ones. He found no single defining moment, no miracle product, no dramatic turnaround. Instead, he described a “flywheel”: a heavy wheel pushed consistently in one direction, turn after turn, until it built unstoppable momentum. Leaders inside these companies often struggled to name a single turning point — because there wasn’t one. There were thousands of small pushes.

BUILD IT

How to generate momentum

Start with an easy win

Start with an easy win to reduce resistance. Your first action of the day sets the tone for the next ones. Make your bed. Drink a glass of water. Write one line. The task itself doesn't matter as much as the message it sends: "I am someone who gets things done."

Stack habits

Attach one new micro-habit to an existing routine — this is called **habit stacking**. The formula is simple:

After I [current habit], I will [new micro-habit].

The existing habit becomes the reminder for the new one.

AFTER I...

I WILL...

pour my morning tea

read one page of a book

sit down at my desk

write my minimum viable progress for the day

finish dinner

walk for five minutes

get into bed

write one line in my journal

Keep streaks

Keep streaks for visible momentum. Streaks provide social proof and motivational pressure to continue. Once you've done something twenty days in a row, the streak itself becomes a reason to keep going — you don't want to break it.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

“Don’t break the chain”

One of the most popular productivity ideas of the internet age is often credited to comedian Jerry Seinfeld (though he has said it wasn’t really his idea). The story goes that a young comedian asked for advice, and was told to write jokes every day. Get a big wall calendar. Each day you write, draw a big red X. After a few days you’ll have a chain. Your only job is not to break the chain. Whoever invented it, the method works for the same reason the 1% Rule works: it rewards consistency, not intensity.

KEEP IT

Practical guidance on sustaining momentum

When faced with setbacks, shrink the habit

Illness, travel, exams, a new baby, a difficult month at work — setbacks are guaranteed. When they come, don’t quit the habit; shrink it until it is manageable. Ten minutes of reading becomes one page. A 20-minute walk becomes five. A ₹100 daily transfer becomes ₹10. The size doesn’t matter. The identity does.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

How long does a habit take?

You may have heard that a habit takes 21 days to form. Real research suggests it varies a lot. In a 2009 study at University College London, psychologist Phillippa Lally and colleagues followed 96 volunteers building a new daily habit. On average it took about 66 days for the behaviour to become automatic — but the range was huge, from 18 days to 254 days. Importantly, missing a single day did not seriously damage the process. The lesson: be patient, expect it to take a couple of months, and never let one missed day become an excuse to stop.

Use accountability

Use accountability partners or public commitments to preserve momentum. Tell a friend what you're doing and ask them to check in weekly. Join a group that shares daily progress. Post your streak. When someone else is expecting to hear from you, skipping becomes a little harder.

Use visual trackers

Use visual trackers such as calendars, apps, or physical jars to make progress tangible. Put one marble in a jar every time you complete your habit. Colour one square on a grid. Watch a chain of ticks grow. Progress you can see is progress you'll protect.

“At first you must push. Eventually, the wheel spins with its own energy.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Write one habit-stacking sentence: “After I ___, I will ___.”
- ☐ Decide now what the “shrunk” version of your habit will be for bad days.
- ☐ Track it for 30 days on a visible calendar, and tell one person about your streak.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Small, repeatable actions build identity and momentum. Protect the streak, not the size.

Stories of 1% Heroes

Inventors, athletes, teachers and ordinary people who changed their world with relentless, small, consistent action.

Greatness often looks ordinary in the moment because it is built slowly.

CHAPTER 9

Human stories make the 1% Rule tangible. Consider the inventor who tested a small variation every day, the athlete who improved technique by a fraction, or the writer who wrote one page daily. Each story shares a common feature: relentless, small, consistent action.

In this chapter you'll meet some of them. A few are famous. Some are ordinary people who became extraordinary only because they refused to stop. As you read, look past the headline achievement and notice the daily habit underneath it.

PROFILE 01

Thomas Edison: thousands of small experiments

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The laboratory of a thousand tries

Thomas Edison did not “invent the light bulb” in a flash of genius. Electric lights already existed; the problem was making one that was practical, affordable and long-lasting. At his laboratory in Menlo Park, New Jersey, Edison and his team tested thousands of materials for the glowing filament — cotton thread, paper, fishing line, and countless plant fibres from around the world. Each test was a small experiment that ruled one more option out. Eventually, carbonised bamboo produced a filament that could glow for well over a thousand hours.

A quote often attributed to Edison sums up the approach: “I have not failed. I’ve just found 10,000 ways that won’t work.” Whether or not he said exactly those words, his laboratory lived by them. Thousands of small experiments led to invention.

PROFILE 02

The runner: one step at a time

CASE STUDY

Improving cadence by one step per minute

Consider a marathon runner who improved cadence by one step per minute each week. It sounds like nothing — who could even feel the difference? But over a training season, those tiny adjustments meant shorter, lighter strides, less strain on the knees, and a smoother, more efficient rhythm. On race day, he shaved minutes off his finishing time. No new shoes, no miracle diet. One step per minute, one week at a time.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Eliud Kipchoge's notebook

On 12 October 2019, in Vienna, Kenyan runner Eliud Kipchoge became the first person ever to run a marathon distance in under two hours, finishing in 1:59:40 in a specially organised event. What fewer people know is how ordinary his daily routine is. For years he has lived at a simple training camp, done his share of household chores, and written notes in a logbook after training sessions — distance, time, how he felt. He reviews those notebooks to learn from them. His greatest performance was built on thousands of carefully recorded ordinary days.

PROFILE 03

The teacher: one new technique a week

CASE STUDY

Fifty-two small experiments in a classroom

A secondary-school teacher decided to practise one new teaching technique each week. One week it was asking students to explain an answer to the person next to them. Another week it was starting each lesson with a two-minute quiz on the previous one. Another, it was learning every student's name in the first class. Not every experiment worked. But the ones that did stayed. By the end of the year she had a toolkit of dozens of proven techniques — and she saw student engagement rise steadily, term after term.

Dashrath Manjhi: the man who moved a mountain

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Twenty-two years with a hammer and chisel

In the village of Gehlaur in Bihar, a rocky ridge stood between the villagers and the nearest town with a hospital and a school. The journey around it was long and hard. Dashrath Manjhi, a poor labourer, decided to cut a path through the hill himself. According to the widely told story, the decision followed a painful loss: his wife, Falguni Devi, was injured and the distance made it difficult to reach help.

From around 1960 to 1982, with only a hammer and chisel, Manjhi chipped away at the rock — a little every day. Villagers mocked him at first. Twenty-two years later, he had carved a passage through the ridge that dramatically shortened the journey for his village. Today he is remembered across India as the “Mountain Man”, and his story has been told in films and books. No machine could have been more powerful than his daily consistency.

PROFILE 05

Jadav Payeng: the forest man of India

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

One seedling at a time

In 1979, a teenager named Jadav Payeng saw snakes that had died from the heat on a barren sandbar of the Brahmaputra river in As-sam, with no trees to shade them. He began planting bamboo — then other trees — one seedling at a time, watering them by hand. He kept going for decades. The result is a forest now reported to cover around 550 hectares, home to birds, deer, rhinos, tigers and a herd of elephants that returns each year. The forest is named Molai after him. In 2015 he was awarded the Padma Shri, one of India’s highest civilian honours. A forest, it turns out, is just a lot of single trees.

THE PATTERN

What every 1% hero shares

These narratives are less about genius and more about persistence. Look at the pattern across every profile:

HERO	THE SMALL DAILY ACTION	THE RESULT
Edison	One more experiment	A practical electric light
The runner	One step per minute	Minutes off race time
Kipchoge	One logged session	First sub-2-hour marathon distance
The teacher	One technique a week	Rising student engagement
Manjhi	One day of chiselling	A road through a mountain
Payeng	One seedling	A 550-hectare forest

The takeaway: greatness often looks ordinary in the moment because it is built slowly. If you had watched any of these people on a random

THE 1% RULE

Tuesday, you would have seen nothing special — a man hitting a rock, a teenager planting a sapling, a runner writing in a notebook. The magic was never in the single day. It was in refusing to stop.

“Greatness often looks ordinary in the moment because it is built slowly.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose the hero from this chapter whose story moved you most. Write down their “small daily action”.
- ☐ Write your own version: what is the one small thing you could repeat for years?
- ☐ Track it for 30 days on a visible calendar — the first chapter of your own 1% story.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Small, repeatable actions build identity and momentum. Heroes are ordinary people who didn't stop.

The 30-Day Blueprint

A practical, day-by-day plan to apply the 1% Rule for thirty days — adaptable to your life and the time you have.

The goal is transformation through tiny, repeatable actions.

CHAPTER 10

This chapter gives you a practical, day-by-day plan to apply the 1% Rule over 30 days. The goal is transformation through tiny, repeatable actions. The blueprint below is adaptable to your life and the time you have available.

You don't need to change everything at once. You need three small habits, a place to track them, and a few minutes each evening to reflect. By day 30, you will have something more valuable than any single result: proof that you can keep a promise to yourself.

BEFORE DAY 1

Set up in 15 minutes

- **Choose your three areas.** The blueprint uses health, learning and productivity — but swap in money or relationships if they matter more to you right now.
- **Write one micro-action for each.** Each should take five to fifteen minutes and be possible on your worst day.

THE 1% RULE

- **Pick your anchors.** Attach each micro-action to something you already do daily.
- **Print or draw your tracker.** Use the 30-day grid at the end of this chapter, or a calendar on your wall.

THE PLAN

Five phases, thirty days

1–5

DAYS

Establish

Establish three micro-habits (health, learning, productivity). Focus on consistency rather than intensity. If you feel like doing more, you may — but the goal is simply to show up every day.

6–12

DAYS

Reflect and adjust

Add reflection and adjust: journal briefly each night about what worked. If a habit keeps failing, it's too big or badly anchored. Shrink it or move it — don't abandon it.

13–20

DAYS

Stack and share

Stack habits and introduce one social accountability action. Link your habits into a short routine, and tell a friend, join a group, or post your streak.

21–27

DAYS

Stretch

Push for small stretch goals — slightly increase the micro-action. Five minutes becomes seven. Ten pages becomes twelve. Only increase what already feels easy.

28–30

DAYS

Review and celebrate

Review, celebrate, and set the next 30-day plan. Look back at your tracker, read your journal, and decide which habits to keep, grow, or replace.

DAY BY DAY

A sample 30-day plan

Here is one way the blueprint could look for someone with about 30 minutes a day. Treat it as a template, not a rulebook.

DAY	FOCUS	WHAT TO DO
1	Start	Do all three micro-habits: 5-minute walk, 10 pages, one “minimum viable progress” task. Tick the tracker.
2–3	Repeat	Same three habits, same anchors. Resist the urge to add more.
4	Prepare	Set up your environment: shoes by the door, book on the pillow, tomorrow’s task on a sticky note.
5	Check-in	Look at your first five ticks. Celebrate — you’ve started.
6	Journal	Begin a nightly two-minute journal using the prompts below.
7–9	Notice	Notice which habit is hardest. Write down why.
10	Adjust	Shrink or re-anchor the hardest habit so it becomes easy again.
11–12	Steady	Keep going with the adjusted plan. No new additions.
13	Stack	Link your habits: “After my walk, I read. After reading, I plan tomorrow’s task.”
14	Share	Tell one person about your challenge and ask them to check on you.
15	Halfway	Review your tracker and journal. What has changed in how you feel?
16–18	Add	Add one tiny money or relationship action (a ₹20 save, or one sincere message).

THE 1% RULE

DAY	FOCUS	WHAT TO DO
19–20	Protect	Plan for your busiest day this week: what is the shrunk version of each habit?
21	Stretch	Increase one habit slightly — the one that feels easiest.
22–24	Build	Hold the new level. If it feels heavy, step back down without guilt.
25	Stretch	Increase a second habit slightly.
26–27	Hold	Keep the streak alive. Notice how automatic some habits now feel.
28	Review	Read your whole journal. List your three biggest lessons.
29	Celebrate	Mark the achievement — a favourite meal, a small gift, a message to your accountability partner.
30	Plan next	Write your next 30-day plan: keep, grow, or replace each habit.

EVERY DAY

Daily checklist ideas

MOVE

One intentional movement session

5–15 minutes of walking, stretching or exercise.

LEARN

Ten pages or 15 minutes

Ten pages of reading or 15 minutes of deliberate practice.

SAVE

One money micro-save

Rounding up, or a small transfer to savings.

CONNECT

One relationship action

One action to nurture a relationship.

DO

One micro-productivity item

One micro-productivity item completed.

REFLECT

Two minutes of journaling

Answer the three prompts below before bed.

EVERY NIGHT

Journaling prompts

What 1% improvement did I make today?

What resisted me — and why?

One small adjustment for tomorrow:

YOUR TRACKER

The 30-day grid

Tick a box every day you complete your micro-habits. The highlighted days mark the start of each phase. If you miss a day, leave it blank and follow one rule: **never miss twice**.

THE 1% RULE

01	02	03	04	05	06	07
08	09	10	11	12	13	14
15	16	17	18	19	20	21
22	23	24	25	26	27	28
29	30					

“Thirty days won’t change your whole life. It will change what you believe is possible.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose your three micro-habits and write them at the top of your tracker today.
- ☐ Set tomorrow as Day 1 — or better, today.
- ☐ Track it for 30 days on a visible calendar, and journal for two minutes each night.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Small, repeatable actions build identity and momentum. Thirty days of proof beats a lifetime of intention.

PART FOUR

04

Going Deeper

The science under the surface, the mindset traps that keep people at zero, and how to turn the 1% Rule into a way of living.

11 Small Wins · 12 The 0% Mindset · 13 Invisible Progress · 14 At Work · 15 Health & Fitness · 16 The Life Plan

The Science of Small Wins

Why your brain is wired to keep going once it sees progress — and how to use that wiring on purpose.

Momentum is more powerful than motivation.

CHAPTER 11

Every great journey is made of countless small steps. Psychology calls this the “progress principle”: the human brain thrives on small victories. When you make progress — even tiny progress — you feel more motivated to continue.

This chapter looks under the bonnet of the 1% Rule. Why does a small win feel so good? Why does it make the next action easier? And how can you use that wiring on purpose?

The progress principle

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

12,000 diary entries

Harvard Business School professor Teresa Amabile and psychologist Steven Kramer asked 238 people working on creative projects across seven companies to fill in a short diary at the end of every working day. Over several months they collected nearly 12,000 entries describing how people felt and what had happened. When they analysed the data, one factor stood out above all others in boosting people's mood, motivation and creativity: *making progress in meaningful work* — even small progress. They called it “the progress principle” and published the findings in their 2011 book of the same name.

The surprising part wasn't that progress felt good. It was how small the progress could be and still have a large effect. A single solved problem, a small step forward, a minor breakthrough — these were often enough to turn an ordinary day into a good one.

THE BRAIN

What happens inside your head

When you make progress, even tiny progress, your brain's reward system responds. A key messenger in that system is **dopamine** — a chemical often called the “feel-good” molecule, but better described as the “keep going” molecule. Dopamine is closely tied to motivation and learning: it helps the brain notice which actions lead to rewards, and it nudges you to repeat them.

Neuroscientists have found that dopamine signals respond not just to rewards themselves but to *signs* that a reward is coming — cues that you're on the right track. That's why a ticked box, a growing streak or

a slowly filling progress bar can feel satisfying. They are signals of progress, and your brain treats them as reasons to continue.

The 1% Rule is built on this science. A 1% improvement might feel invisible today, but it fuels momentum. And momentum is more powerful than motivation, because once you're moving, you want to keep going.

MOTIVATION**A feeling**

Comes and goes with sleep, mood and stress. Unreliable as a starting point.

MOMENTUM**A system**

Built by action. Each small win makes the next action easier.

THE EFFECT**Closer means faster****● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE****The coffee card experiment**

Researchers at Columbia University, led by Ran Kivetz, ran an experiment with a café loyalty programme. Some customers received a card that needed 10 stamps for a free coffee. Others received a card that needed 12 stamps — but came with 2 stamps already filled in. Both groups needed exactly 10 purchases. Yet the customers who *felt* they had already made progress completed their cards faster. People speed up as they sense they are getting closer to a goal — psychologists call this the **goal-gradient effect**.

The lesson for you: make your progress visible early. Start your tracker with a tick on day one. Break big goals into small milestones so you are always “close” to the next one. The feeling of being on your way is itself fuel.

Small wins solve big problems

In 1984, organisational psychologist Karl Weick wrote an influential paper titled “Small Wins: Redefining the Scale of Social Problems”. He argued that when problems feel enormous — poverty, pollution, disease — people freeze. The size of the challenge produces anxiety, and anxiety reduces our ability to think and act. Weick’s solution was to break big problems into “small wins”: concrete, completed, manageable results. Each small win reduces anxiety, builds confidence, and attracts allies — creating the conditions for the next win.

USE IT

Design your own small wins

- **Make the finish line close.** Define “done” for today in something you can finish in under 30 minutes.
- **Mark every win.** Tick it, colour it, or write it on your done list. Visible progress triggers the reward.
- **Pre-fill the card.** Count what you’ve already done. You’re rarely starting from zero.
- **Review weekly.** Look back every Sunday at your wins. Small progress is easy to forget and powerful to remember.

“Momentum is more powerful than motivation, because once you’re moving, you want to keep going.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ At the end of today, write down three small wins — however tiny.
- ☐ Break your biggest current goal into milestones you can reach with-in a week each.
- ☐ Keep a “small wins” list for 30 days and read it back on the last day.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Small wins fuel consistency and long-term achievement.

Breaking the 0% Mindset

The biggest enemy of progress isn't failure. It's waiting for the perfect time to begin.

Imperfect action beats perfect intention.

CHAPTER 12

The biggest enemy of progress isn't failure — it's inaction. Failure at least produces feedback. Inaction produces nothing at all.

Too often, people wait for the “perfect time” to begin. They tell themselves they'll start when they're ready, when life settles down, when they feel motivated. After the exams. After the wedding. After the new job. After the holidays. On Monday. On the first of the month. In the new year.

But waiting leads to the **0% mindset**: no action, no progress. The truth is, imperfect action beats perfect intention.

THE TRAP

Why we wait

We wait to feel motivated

We imagine motivation arrives first and action follows. In reality, it often works the other way around. Psychologists who treat low mood

use an approach called *behavioural activation*, built on a simple observation: doing small, meaningful activities tends to lift mood and energy, rather than waiting for mood to lift before acting. Action creates motivation more often than motivation creates action.

We wait for perfect conditions

There is no perfect time. Life never fully “settles down”; it just changes shape. The person waiting for a quiet month is still waiting ten years later.

We wait for a perfect plan

Planning feels productive. It isn't — not after a point. Psychologists Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky described the *planning fallacy*: our tendency to underestimate how long things will take, even when we have plenty of past experience. Endless planning doesn't fix this. Starting does, because action gives you real information that no plan can.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

“If you're not embarrassed...”

LinkedIn co-founder Reid Hoffman is known for a piece of advice to start-up founders: “If you are not embarrassed by the first version of your product, you've launched too late.” His point is that waiting for perfection is expensive. A rough first version gets into the real world, collects real feedback, and improves quickly. A perfect version that never ships helps no one. The same is true of habits: an embarrassing first workout, a messy first page, a tiny first saving beats a perfect plan that never begins.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Started with \$5,000 and a borrowed evening

Sara Blakely was selling fax machines door to door when she had an idea for a new kind of undergarment. She had no background in fashion, business or manufacturing. Instead of waiting until she had the right degree, the right contacts or the right savings, she started with about \$5,000 of her own money, worked on the idea in her spare time, and even researched and wrote much of her own patent application to save on legal fees. The company she built, Spanx, made her one of the world's best-known self-made entrepreneurs. It started with small, imperfect steps taken before she felt ready.

THE SHIFT

From 0% to 1%

Taking that first 1% step today — however small — immediately shifts you out of 0% and into growth. The gap between 0% and 1% is the most important gap in this whole book. Mathematically, 1.01^{365} is almost 38. But 1.00^{365} is exactly 1. Doing nothing, however comfortably, compounds into nothing.

$$1.00^{365} = 1 \quad \cdot \quad 1.01^{365} \approx 38$$

Zero percent, repeated forever, is still zero progress.

How to break the 0% mindset today

THE 0% THOUGHT	THE 1% REPLY
"I'll start when I'm ready."	"I'll start small, and get ready while I go."
"I don't have time."	"I have two minutes. That's enough to begin."
"I need a proper plan first."	"My first step is my plan. I'll adjust tomorrow."
"It won't make a difference."	"It will — compounded. One percent is not zero."
"I'll start on Monday."	"Today is a perfectly good day to be one percent better."

The two-minute start

Whenever you catch yourself waiting, ask: *What is the two-minute version of this?* Open the document and write one sentence. Put on your walking shoes and step outside. Open your banking app and move ₹10. Two minutes is too small to fear and just big enough to break the spell of zero.

“ Imperfect action beats perfect intention.

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Write down one thing you've been "waiting for the right time" to start.
- ☐ Define its two-minute version — and do it within the next hour.
- ☐ Each time a 0% thought appears in the next 30 days, write the 1% reply beside it.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Action in any form is better than waiting for perfection.

Invisible Progress

The hardest stretch of the journey is when you can't yet see results. That is exactly when persistence matters most.

Invisible growth is still growth.

CHAPTER 13

The hardest part of the 1% journey is when you can't yet see results. In these moments, many people give up.

You've walked every day for three weeks and the scale hasn't moved. You've saved every month and the balance still looks small. You've practised the guitar for a month and still sound like a beginner. It is at exactly this point — when effort is high and visible reward is low — that most people quietly stop.

But this is exactly when persistence matters most.

THE METAPHOR

Think of the bamboo

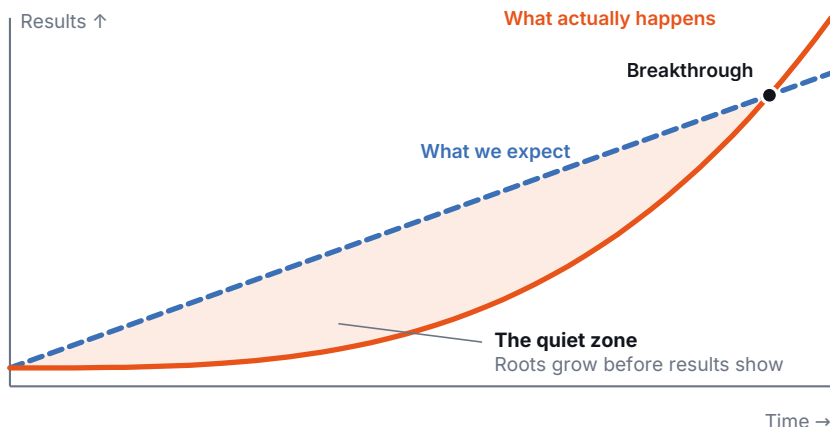
Think of a bamboo plant. Some species, such as the giant Moso bamboo, can spend years building a vast network of roots and underground stems, with little to show above the soil. Then, once that foundation is in place, new shoots rise astonishingly fast — at their peak, some bamboo shoots can grow close to a metre in a single day.

THE 1% RULE

Anyone watching during the early years would think nothing was happening. They would be wrong. The growth was simply underground. Progress works the same way. **Invisible growth is still growth.**

Expectation vs. reality

Why the early stretch of any 1% journey feels disappointing



The quiet zone is where most people quit — because results lag behind effort. Stay long enough and the curve bends upward.

UNDER THE SURFACE

Where invisible progress hides

In your body

When people start strength training, they often get noticeably stronger within the first few weeks — long before their muscles look any bigger. Exercise scientists explain that much of this early improvement comes from the nervous system learning to activate muscles more efficiently. The change is real. It just isn't visible in the mirror yet.

In your skills

Language learners often describe a long stretch where they understand more and more but still can't speak fluently — and then, sometimes quite suddenly, words start to flow. The vocabulary and patterns were building quietly the whole time.

In your money

As Chapter 5 showed, in the early years of investing your balance is mostly your own contributions. Growth looks tiny. Decades later, growth dominates. The early years weren't wasted; they were the roots.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

The stonecutter's hundred and first blow

Jacob Riis, a Danish-American journalist and social reformer of the late 1800s, kept a note about persistence that has been quoted in sports locker rooms ever since. When nothing seemed to help, he wrote, he would go and look at a stonecutter hammering away at his rock, perhaps a hundred times without so much as a crack showing in it. Yet at the hundred and first blow it would split in two — “and I knew it was not that last blow that did it, but all that had gone before.”

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Twelve rejections

Before *Harry Potter and the Philosopher's Stone* was published in 1997, J.K. Rowling's manuscript was reportedly turned down by around a dozen publishers. She was a single parent living on very little, writing in cafés when she could. From the outside, years of work had produced nothing but rejection letters. Underneath, a world was being built — one chapter at a time. When it finally broke through, it became one of the best-selling book series in history.

How to survive the quiet zone

- **Measure inputs, not only outputs.** You can't control when results show up. You can control whether you did the action today. Track that.
- **Look for leading signs.** Better sleep, more energy, easier starts, clearer thinking — these often arrive long before the big result.
- **Compare with day one, not with other people.** Your journal and tracker are proof of how far you've come.
- **Expect the quiet zone.** Knowing it is coming makes it far less discouraging when it does.
- **Remember water.** Heat water from 20°C to 99°C and it still looks like water. At 100°C it boils. Every degree before that mattered.

“It was not the last blow that did it, but all that had gone before.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ List three “invisible” signs of progress you’ve noticed since starting your 1% habits.
- ☐ Change your tracker to record inputs (did I do it?) rather than outcomes (did it work yet?).
- ☐ Commit to 30 more days before judging any habit by its results.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Growth often happens underground before it becomes visible.

The 1% Rule at Work

You don't need to reinvent yourself overnight. You need to get slightly better each day — one skill, one process, one connection.

In business and career, the 1% Rule is a secret weapon.

CHAPTER 14

In business and career, the 1% Rule is a secret weapon. You don't need to reinvent yourself overnight — you need to get slightly better each day.

Careers are rarely transformed by one brilliant moment. They are shaped by thousands of small decisions: the extra ten minutes spent understanding a problem, the email written clearly instead of carelessly, the colleague you helped without being asked, the new tool you learned on a slow Friday afternoon. Learn one new skill, improve one process, make one stronger connection — and repeat.

THE 1% RULE

SKILL

Learn one new thing

A shortcut, a formula, a concept, a better way to present.

PROCESS

Improve one process

Remove one step, one delay, one source of mistakes.

CONNECTION

Strengthen one relationship

Thank someone, help someone, ask someone a good question.

REFLECTION

Review one lesson

What worked this week? What will I do 1% better next week?

ORGANISATIONS

Companies that improve continuously

Companies that embrace continuous improvement often outperform competitors because they focus on consistent growth rather than chasing perfection.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Toyota and the andon cord

The Toyota Production System, developed in Japan in the decades after the Second World War, is one of the most studied examples of continuous improvement — *kaizen* — in the world. One of its best-known features is the *andon* cord: any worker on the production line who spots a problem can pull it to signal for help, and the line can be stopped so the issue is fixed at its source. Instead of hiding small problems, the system surfaces them and solves them one by one, every day. Over decades, those countless small fixes helped Toyota build a global reputation for quality and reliability.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

From “know-it-all” to “learn-it-all”

When Satya Nadella became chief executive of Microsoft in 2014, he set out to change its culture. Inspired by psychologist Carol Dweck’s work on the “growth mindset”, he encouraged employees to move from being “know-it-alls” to “learn-it-alls” — people who expect to keep improving rather than people who need to be right. The shift is widely credited as an important part of Microsoft’s renewal in the years that followed. It is the 1% Rule at the scale of a whole company: a culture where getting slightly better is expected every day.

YOUR CAREER

The 1% professional

1. Protect a daily learning block

Fifteen minutes at the start of the day — before email — to learn something that makes you better at your job. Over a year that is more than 90 hours of focused professional development, without a single course fee.

2. Fix one friction point a week

Every job has small annoyances: a report that takes too long, a template that confuses people, a file nobody can find. Fix one each week. After a year you have removed 50 friction points — for yourself and often for your whole team.

3. Make one stronger connection

Send a genuine thank-you. Ask a senior colleague one thoughtful question. Help a new team member find their feet. Small, consistent acts of generosity build a reputation faster than any self-promotion.

4. Run a weekly 1% review

Every Friday, spend ten minutes answering three questions:

THE 1% RULE

QUESTION

EXAMPLE ANSWER

What did I improve this week?

Cut the weekly report from 40 minutes to 25 with a new template.

What slowed me down?

Too many meetings on Tuesday. Blocked focus time next week.

What is next week's 1%?

Learn pivot tables properly — 15 minutes a day.

CASE STUDY

Kabir's 1% year

Kabir was a junior analyst who felt stuck. Instead of waiting for a big break, he began spending fifteen minutes each morning improving one skill — spreadsheet formulas first, then data visualisation, then presentation. Every Friday he wrote down one process he'd improved. By the end of the year his manager noticed that Kabir's reports were the ones everyone else copied. His promotion didn't come from a single brilliant project. It came from a year of being slightly better every week.

“ You don't need to reinvent yourself overnight. You need to get slightly better each day.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Block fifteen minutes in your calendar tomorrow morning for learning, before email.
- ☐ Name one friction point in your work and fix it this week.
- ☐ Run a 1% review every Friday for the next 30 days.

KEY TAKEAWAY

In work and career, daily micro-improvements lead to exponential growth.

The 1% Rule for Health & Fitness

No radical diets. No extreme workouts. Just consistent, tiny changes that stack into lasting fitness and energy.

Health thrives on small lifestyle changes that stick.

CHAPTER 15

Health transformations don't require radical diets or extreme workouts. They require consistent, tiny changes: drinking more water daily, walking an extra 1,000 steps, sleeping 30 minutes earlier, swapping one unhealthy snack for a healthier one.

These habits are small, but they stack over time into lasting fitness and energy. Chapter 3 showed why health is the foundation for everything else. This chapter goes deeper into four specific 1% changes — and the science that supports them.

+1,000

Extra steps a day — about 10 minutes of walking

30 min

Earlier to bed — about 182 extra hours of sleep a year

1 swap

One unhealthy snack replaced every day

CHANGE 01

Drink more water daily

Mild dehydration can leave you tired, foggy and headachy — and it's easy to mistake thirst for hunger. Health authorities such as the European Food Safety Authority suggest adults aim for roughly 2 to 2.5 litres of total water a day from all drinks and food, with needs rising in hot weather and with exercise. You don't need to track every millilitre. Just add one glass: first thing in the morning, with every meal, or every time you sit down at your desk.

CHANGE 02

Walk an extra 1,000 steps

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Every thousand steps counts

In 2023, a team led by cardiologist Maciej Banach published a large analysis in the *European Journal of Preventive Cardiology*, combining data from 17 studies and more than 225,000 people. They found that each additional 1,000 steps a day was associated with about a 15% lower risk of death from any cause. Benefits appeared at step counts far lower than the famous 10,000 — and kept growing as people walked more. You don't need a marathon. You need one more short walk.

One thousand steps is roughly 10 minutes of walking. Take the stairs. Walk while you're on phone calls. Get off the bus one stop early. Walk to a shop instead of ordering in. Over a year, an extra 1,000 steps a day adds up to more than a third of a million steps — hundreds of kilometres — without a single gym visit.

● REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE**One-minute “exercise snacks”**

A 2022 study in *Nature Medicine*, led by Emmanuel Stamatakis, used wrist-worn activity trackers to study more than 25,000 adults who didn’t formally exercise. Those who did short bursts of vigorous everyday activity — climbing stairs briskly, rushing for a bus, carrying heavy shopping — for about one to two minutes at a time, three times a day, had a markedly lower risk of early death than those who did none. Researchers nicknamed these bursts “exercise snacks”. They are the 1% Rule in physical form.

CHANGE 03**Sleep 30 minutes earlier**

Leading sleep organisations such as the American Academy of Sleep Medicine recommend that adults sleep at least seven hours a night on a regular basis. Many people fall short, not because they can’t sleep, but because the evening slips away on screens. The 1% fix is simple: move your bedtime 30 minutes earlier. Set an alarm for bedtime, not just for waking. Put your phone on charge outside the bedroom. Dim the lights half an hour before you plan to sleep.

CHANGE 04**Swap one unhealthy snack**

You don’t need to overhaul your diet. Just swap one thing. A packet of chips for a handful of peanuts. A sugary drink for water with lemon or buttermilk. A biscuit for a piece of fruit. One swap, repeated daily, removes hundreds of empty calories a week and slowly retrains your taste. After a month, the old snack often starts to taste too sweet or too salty.

THE 1% RULE

INSTEAD OF...	TRY...
Sugary soft drink	Water, lemon water, or chaas (buttermilk)
Packet chips	Roasted chana or a handful of peanuts
Biscuits with tea	A banana, apple, or a few dates
Late-night sweets	A small bowl of curd with fruit

PUT IT TOGETHER

Your 1% health stack

Don't start all four changes on the same day. Pick one, run it for two weeks until it feels automatic, then add the next. By the end of two months you'll have a complete health stack — built without a single “diet day” or punishing workout.

This chapter is general information, not medical advice. If you have a health condition, are pregnant, or are unsure what is safe for you, speak with a doctor before changing your diet or activity levels.

“Health thrives on small lifestyle changes that stick.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Choose one of the four changes in this chapter and start it today.
- ☐ After two weeks, add a second change. After four weeks, a third.
- ☐ Track all your health habits for 30 days and note your energy level (1–10) each evening.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Health thrives on small lifestyle changes that stick.

The 1% Life Plan

The 1% Rule isn't just about goals — it's a way of living. Here is how to build your own plan.

A year from now, you won't recognise the person you've become.

CHAPTER 16

The 1% Rule isn't just about goals — it's a way of living. If you decide to get a little better every day, life becomes an upward journey.

Goals end. You hit the target, or you don't, and then you need a new one. A way of living doesn't end. It becomes the background of your days: a quiet, steady commitment to be slightly better than yesterday in whatever matters most to you right now. That is what this final chapter is about — turning everything in this book into a plan you can live by.

THE METHOD

Build your 1% Life Plan in four steps

1

STEP

Identify one area you want to grow

Health, learning, money, productivity, relationships, work — or something personal to you. Choose the one that would make the biggest difference if it improved. Just one for now.

2

STEP

Choose a small daily action

Make it so small you can do it on your worst day. Attach it to something you already do. Write it as a sentence: “After I ____, I will ____.”

3

STEP

Track your progress weekly

Tick it daily, review it weekly. Every Sunday, look at the week: how many days, what helped, what got in the way, and what to adjust.

4

STEP

Celebrate small wins

Mark every milestone — 7 days, 30 days, 100 days. Celebration tells your brain that this matters, and makes the next week easier.

● **REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE**

Benjamin Franklin’s little book

At around the age of twenty, Benjamin Franklin — later a scientist, inventor, writer and one of the founders of the United States — decided to work on his character. He listed thirteen virtues, including temperance, order, frugality, industry and sincerity. Instead of trying to master them all at once, he focused on just one each week. He kept a small book with a table for each virtue and the days of the week, marking a dot each day he fell short. After thirteen weeks he started the cycle again, completing it four times a year. He wrote in his autobiography that he never reached perfection, but that he was “a better and a happier man” than he would otherwise have been. That is a 1% Life Plan, written more than 250 years ago.

YOUR TURN

My 1% Life Plan

Fill this in now — in the book, in a notebook, or on your phone. Keep it where you will see it every week.

The one area I want to grow:

Why it matters to me:

My small daily action — “After I ___, I will ___”:

How I will track it, and when I will review it each week:

How I will celebrate at 7, 30 and 100 days:

THE LONG VIEW

A year of 1%

Once your first habit becomes automatic — usually within two or three months — add a second area. Then a third. Over a year, your Life Plan might look like this:

THE 1% RULE

QUARTER	FOCUS AREA	DAILY 1% ACTION
Months 1–3	Health	10-minute walk after dinner
Months 4–6	Learning	10 pages before bed
Months 7–9	Money	Automatic daily round-up + monthly SIP
Months 10–12	Relationships	One sincere message every morning

By the end of the year, you are not doing one small thing — you are doing four, all on autopilot. You walk, you read, you save, you connect. None of it feels heroic. All of it compounds.

A year from now, you won't recognise the person you've become — and it all started with one small step.

“A year from now, you won't recognise the person you've become.”

ACTION STEPS

- ☐ Complete your 1% Life Plan above before you close this book.
- ☐ Put a weekly review in your calendar — same day, same time, ten minutes.
- ☐ Track your first area for 30 days, then decide when to add the next.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Life mastery is built on daily improvements, not overnight transformations.

Conclusion

The difference between an ordinary life and an extraordinary one is rarely a single dramatic event.

Start today. The future you will thank you.

THE 1% RULE

The difference between an ordinary life and an extraordinary one is rarely a single dramatic event. It is small choices, day after day.

Throughout this book you've met people who proved it. A cycling team that improved everything by one percent. A janitor who quietly saved a fortune. A novelist with a watch on his desk. A labourer who carved a road through a mountain. A teenager who planted a forest. None of them had a secret. They had a small action, and they refused to stop repeating it.

The 1% Rule is both a method and a philosophy: choose the smallest useful action and commit to it. If you do, the mathematics of compounding will reward you beyond what imagination initially allows.

THE 1% RULE

REMEMBER

The 1% Rule on one page

PRINCIPLE	IN ONE LINE
Start small	Choose an action you can do on your worst day.
Compound	1% better daily is almost 38 times better in a year.
Track it	Visible progress is progress you'll protect.
Stack it	"After I ___, I will ___."
Shrink, don't quit	On hard days, do the smallest version.
Never miss twice	One missed day is life. Two is a new habit.
Trust the quiet zone	Invisible growth is still growth.
Break the 0%	Imperfect action beats perfect intention.
Celebrate	Small wins fuel the next small win.

Start today. The future you will thank you.

FINAL CHALLENGE

Start your first 30-day 1% experiment today. Pick one small action and commit to it.

My first 1% action is:

SIGNATURE

START DATE

Acknowledgements

Thanks to readers, mentors, and those small people who showed up daily to do the work. This book exists because of tiny acts repeated over time.

To every reader who picked one small action from these pages and kept going: you are the reason this book was worth writing — and worth expanding.

Veer Sukhadiya

Veer Sukhadiya is the author of *The 1% Rule* and the founder of Veeer Sukhadiya Books. He writes practical, encouraging guides about building a better life through small, consistent steps — books designed not only to be read, but to be used.

Notes & Sources

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